

GIACOMO CASANOVA'S UNFAILING LUCK: THE PROBLEM OF SILENT EVIDENCE

The Diagoras problem—How Black Swans make their way out of history books—Methods to help you avoid drowning—The drowned do not usually vote—We should all be stockbrokers—Do silent witnesses count?—Casanova's étoile—New York is "so invincible"

Another fallacy in the way we understand events is that of silent evidence. History hides both Black Swans and its Black Swan—generating ability from us.

THE STORY OF THE DROWNED WORSHIPPERS

More than two thousand years ago, the Roman orator, belletrist, thinker, Stoic, manipulator-politician, and (usually) virtuous gentleman, Marcus Tullius Cicero, presented the following story. One Diagoras, a nonbeliever in the gods, was shown painted tablets bearing the portraits of some worshippers who prayed, then survived a subsequent shipwreck. The implication was that praying protects you from drowning. Diagoras asked, "Where were the pictures of those who prayed, then drowned?"

The drowned worshippers, being dead, would have a lot of trouble advertising their experiences from the bottom of the sea. This can fool the casual observer into believing in miracles.

We call this the problem of silent evidence. The idea is simple, yet potent and universal. While most thinkers try to put to shame those who came *before* them, Cicero puts to shame almost all empirical thinkers who came *after* him, until very recently.

Later on, both my hero of heroes, the essayist Michel de Montaigne and the empirical Francis Bacon, mentioned the point in their works, applying it to the formation of false beliefs. "And such is the way of all superstition, whether in astrology, dreams, omens, divine judgments, or the like," wrote Bacon in his *Novum Organum*. The problem, of course, is that unless they are drilled into us systematically, or integrated into our way of thinking, these great observations are rapidly forgotten.

Silent evidence pervades everything connected to the notion of *history*. By history, I don't just mean those learned-but-dull books in the history section